In the warfare of the Middle Ages, cavalry were in the ascendant across most of Eurasia. A high-status warrior was by definition a horseman. In the Byzantine Empire, armoured cavalry known as cataphracts were the core of the armed forces by the 6th century. The Arab armies that, inspired by the new creed of Islam, swept east as far as Afghanistan and west through North Africa and into Spain in the 7th and 8th centuries, achieved their conquests on horseback. The armoured knight of medieval western Europe, charging with lance, is of course one of the most iconic fighting men in military history.

TURKS AND MONGOLS

The most consistently successful of medieval mounted warriors emerged from the tough nomadic peoples of Central Asia. Fighting with the composite bow as their primary weapon, they repeatedly defeated the slower-moving armies of settled civilizations. Both the Turkish Seljuks, who crushed the Byzantine army at Manzikert in 1071, and the Jurchen who conquered the northern part of the Chinese Song Empire in the following century, were Asian horsemen. The most famous of these steppe warriors, however, are the Mongols, whose astonishing conquests began under Genghis Khan in the early 13th century. By the time Genghis's grandson Kublai Khan died

Battle of Hastings
The Norman army that defeated the Anglo-Saxons at Hastings on 14 October, 1066 was a balanced force of cavalry and foot soldiers. The heavy cavalry did not yet have the social status of the medieval knight; they were professional fighting men who could afford to own a warhorse.







